B-17 CREW UNIFORM

Bomber crews were fitted out to survive the rigours of high-altitude operations. Clothing had to keep the men warm when temperatures inside the aircraft could drop well below zero. Electrically heated suits were introduced as an alternative to thick clothing, but crew tended to favour leather and fleece regardless. In the thin upper air, an artificial oxygen supply was essential – if it failed a man would lose consciousness in minutes. The crew also had to be prepared for bailing out at any time.

B10 flying jacket

Flying jacket
The B10 flying jacket was made of tightly woven cotton lined with alpaca. It featured a fur collar and knitted wrists and waistband for body warmth retention. It was initially introduced in 1943 and became a template for flying jacket designs. The D1 jacket was of an earlier design, but saw service up until the Korean War.

D1 flying jacket

A11 helmet
The A11 helmet was standard for all aircrews and had integral earphones and snaps to cover the A14 oxygen mask. The B8 goggles had a chamois lining for extra comfort in the cold, and came with clear, amber, red, or green lenses to cope with various light conditions.

B8 goggles

A14 oxygen mask

Hose connects to oxygen tank



Fastening oxygen mask to helmet



Rip cord at back of parachute



Front of harness, with rip cord to right